Global Intelligence Report

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1. OVERALL_SUMMARY: The Return of the Monroe Doctrine and the Fracturing of Global Order

The first week of 2026 has witnessed a geopolitical seismic shift that fundamentally alters the calculus of international relations, effectively terminating the lingering post-Cold War assumptions of a "Rules-Based International Order." The execution of **Operation Absolute Resolve**—the United States military's decapitation strike against the Venezuelan government and the subsequent extraction of Nicolás Maduro to New York—marks the definitive operationalization of a new American grand strategy.[1] This event, combined with the release of the 2025 US National Security Strategy (NSS), signals a transition from a unipolar system attempting to police the global commons to a unipolar power engaging in aggressive retrenchment and hegemonic consolidation within its own hemisphere.[3]

From a structural realist perspective, utilizing Kenneth Waltz's theoretical framework, the international system is undergoing a rapid, violent rebalancing. Waltz argued that in an anarchic system, states must rely on self-help to ensure survival. The United States has signaled that it no longer views multilateral institutions or alliance networks as the primary guarantors of its security. Instead, it has adopted a posture of "Civilizational Realism" and "Hard Sovereignty," prioritizing the exclusion of rival great powers—specifically China and Russia—from the Western Hemisphere over the maintenance of global norms.[3] The US has effectively communicated that the Western Hemisphere is a closed sphere of influence, reviving the Monroe Doctrine with a kinetic intensity not seen since the 1989 invasion of Panama.[5]

This unilateralism has generated a "security dilemma" of the highest order. By disregarding international legal norms to secure its "backyard," Washington has signaled to rival great powers that spheres of influence are now the dominant currency of global power. Russia has immediately leveraged this to justify its continued aggression in Ukraine, framing the US action as permission for great powers to dictate terms to their neighbors.[6] The Kremlin perceives the US retreat into hemispheric dominance as a tacit acknowledgment that the era of global liberal hegemony is over, creating a permissive environment for Russian revanchism in Eastern Europe.

Simultaneously, the vacuum of global leadership is accelerating chaos in the periphery. The

international system is exhibiting signs of "anarchic drift," where regional conflicts expand without the dampening effect of superpower mediation. Sudan is fracturing into de facto states as the conflict between the SAF and RSF solidifies into an East-West divide.[7] The Sahel is being overrun by jihadist insurgencies, forcing the US to issue travel bans rather than deploy security assistance.[8] Southeast Asia is witnessing renewed border conflicts between Thailand and Cambodia, further destabilizing the ASEAN bloc.[9]

The global system in 2026 is defined by the naked pursuit of national interest, unadorned by the rhetoric of liberal internationalism. The hegemon is no longer a stabilizer but a disruptor, forcing middle powers—such as the United Kingdom, France, Poland, and Japan—to rapidly militarize and seek new, narrower security architectures to survive in a world where the old guardrails have been demolished.

2. UNITED STATES_STRATEGY: The "Trump Corollary" in Action

The events of this reporting period serve as the kinetic validation of the **2025 National Security Strategy (NSS)**, released in December 2025. This document, characterized by the doctrine of "Civilizational Realism," represents a radical departure from seventy years of American foreign policy, replacing the post-Cold War consensus with a laser focus on homeland survival and economic nationalism.[3]

Doctrinal Shift: "Hard Sovereignty" vs. Globalism

The 2025 NSS explicitly rebukes the concept of global leadership through alliance networks, trade integration, and the promotion of democratic values. Instead, it posits that the United States is a nation "under siege" from internal subversion and external economic predation.[3] The strategy replaces the "Democracy vs. Autocracy" framework of the Biden era with a transactional, interest-based approach. The operationalization of this strategy was visible in Caracas on January 3. The capture of Maduro was not justified through UN resolutions or multilateral coalitions, but through the lens of "protecting the American people from narco-trafficking" and securing the homeland.[10]

This is the "Trump Corollary" to the Monroe Doctrine: the US claims the absolute right to intervene in the Western Hemisphere to exclude foreign influence (China/Russia) and neutralize threats, regardless of sovereignty.[3] The strategy paints a picture of the US as a "sovereign republic" rather than the leader of a "free world," emphasizing the nation-state as the only legitimate political unit and rejecting supranational obligations.[3]

Strategic Priorities & Implementation

The strategy outlines several core pillars that are now driving US behavior:

- **Border Security as National Security:** The NSS elevates border control to the primary element of national security, framing migration as an invasion. It explicitly states, "The era of mass migration must end".[11] The Venezuela operation is partly framed as a method to halt the source of migration flows, aligning domestic political promises with foreign military action. The administration views border integrity not as a law enforcement issue but as an existential threat to the republic.
- **Economic Nationalism and Re-Industrialization:** The strategy emphasizes "Re-shoring" and supply chain independence.[11] It calls for returning economic freedom via tax cuts and deregulation, making the US the premier place to invest capital.[11] The swift move to claim that US oil companies will "run" Venezuela's energy sector [12] underscores the resource-mercantilist aspect of this new strategy. It is a return to direct resource acquisition facilitated by military power, aiming to ensure the US is never dependent on outside powers for critical resources.[11]
- **Technological Supremacy:** The NSS identifies AI, biotech, and quantum computing as vital interests that the US must dominate.[11] This drives the administration's focus on protecting intellectual property and decoupling from Chinese technology, viewing economic competition as a zero-sum game.[14] The strategy explicitly aims to ensure US standards in these technologies "drive the world forward".[11]
- **Civilizational Realism:** The document warns of "civilizational erasure" in Europe due to mass migration and regulatory suffocation, echoing nativist rhetoric.[3] This ideological stance creates a friction point with traditional European allies, as the US administration views the current European sociopolitical model as a failure to be avoided rather than a partner to be emulated.

Global Implications of the US Shift

The execution of this strategy has immediate ripple effects. By effectively abandoning the "policeman of the world" role in Eurasia to focus on hemispheric dominance, the US has terrified its European allies. The lack of prior consultation with NATO partners regarding the Venezuela strike [5] demonstrates that alliances are now viewed as tools of convenience rather than binding commitments. The US has signaled it will act unilaterally and lethally to secure its perceived core interests, leaving allies to manage Eurasian security largely on their own.[14] The strategy's dismissal of "forever wars" in the Middle East [11] suggests a continued drawdown of US presence in regions not deemed vital to immediate homeland security, creating vacuums that regional powers will scramble to fill.

3. UNITED KINGDOM_STRATEGY: The "Fortress Britain" Pivot

In stark contrast to the US retreat into hemispheric unilateralism, the United Kingdom's **National Security Strategy 2025**, titled "Security for the British People in a Dangerous World," represents a desperate bid to harden the nation against a collapsing order.[15] While the US strategy is offensive and revisionist, the UK strategy is defensive and status-quo oriented, seeking to hold the line in Europe even as its primary guarantor steps away.

Strategic Divergence: "Security at Home" and "Strength Abroad"

The UK NSS doubles down on alliances, particularly NATO, the G7, and the Five Eyes, viewing them as essential force multipliers in an era of "radical uncertainty".[15] However, recognizing the potential unreliability of the US—a silent acknowledgment of the shift in Washington—the UK has committed to a historic increase in defense spending, targeting **5% of GDP by 2035**.[17] This is a "war footing" budget, acknowledging that the peace dividend is definitively over and that the UK must be prepared for a potential wartime scenario.[18]

Key Pillars of UK Strategy

- **Total Defense and Societal Resilience:** The strategy emphasizes "Security at Home," integrating economic security, border control, and societal resilience. The government explicitly warns that the country must "actively prepare for the possibility of the UK coming under direct threat".[18] This involves expanding law enforcement toolkits to make the UK a "harder target" for hostile state actors and criminal gangs.[15]
- **Technological Asymmetry:** Unlike the US focus on brute industrial might, the UK is prioritizing "sovereign and asymmetric capabilities" in AI, quantum computing, and engineering biology.[15] The goal is to secure a "first-adopter advantage" to compensate for smaller mass.[15] The strategy outlines a dedicated "Research Security Strategy" to protect these intellectual assets from theft by systemic competitors.[15]
- **Critical Infrastructure Protection:** A specific anxiety permeates the UK strategy regarding subsea infrastructure. With 99% of digital data and approximately three-quarters of the UK's gas supply dependent on subsea cables and pipelines, the protection of this infrastructure is elevated to a tier-one national security priority.[15] The Royal Navy is pivoting to protect these arteries from Russian hybrid warfare, evidenced by the focus on capabilities like the "Borealis" system for space and surveillance.[15]

Comparative Analysis: US vs. UK

The divergence is striking. The US strategy seeks to reshape its near-abroad through force (Venezuela) and extract value (oil/tariffs), driven by a belief that the global order no longer serves American interests.[4] The UK strategy seeks to protect the existing order against revisionist powers like Russia, even as the US steps away. The UK is effectively preparing for a scenario where it must fight a European war without the full weight of American power,

necessitating a "whole of society" mobilization and a cultural shift in government to navigate difficult trade-offs.[15]

4. REGIONAL_ANALYSIS

Western Europe

The continent is reeling from the dual shocks of US unilateralism and internal political fragility. **France** is paralyzed by a severe political crisis following a hung parliament and the collapse of successive minority governments (Barnier, Bayrou), leaving the budget in limbo and debt spiraling.[20] This paralysis weakens Europe's ability to act cohesively at a moment of maximum danger. In **Germany**, political polarization has spilled onto the streets, with left-wing militants attacking the power grid in Berlin, leaving thousands without heat in a protest linking climate crisis and AI.[21] The invitation of the far-right AfD to the Munich Security Conference, following pressure from US Vice President JD Vance, signals the growing influence of the American populist right on European institutions and a breakdown of the "firewall" against the far-right.[22] Europe realizes it is arguably alone; the US violation of international law in Venezuela makes it difficult for European leaders to rally the Global South against Russian violations in Ukraine.[19]

Eastern Europe

The war in **Ukraine** has entered a grim phase. Russian forces captured over 4,300 square kilometers of territory in 2025, grinding down Ukrainian defenses through mass and attrition.[23] While President Zelensky denies the loss of key towns near Pokrovsk, the trend line is negative, and the Ukrainian General Staff reports significant Russian personnel losses that Moscow appears willing to absorb.[24] **Poland** is reacting by accelerating its military buildup, with Prime Minister Donald Tusk declaring 2026 the year of "rapid conquest of the Baltic Sea" and promising to build the strongest army in Europe.[26] The Baltic states are acutely aware that if the US can violate sovereignty in Venezuela, the moral argument protecting them from Russia weakens. They are shifting toward regional defense pacts (Nordic-Baltic-Polish) as faith in the US security umbrella wavers.[27]

North America

The **United States** is consolidating its "Fortress America" posture. The domestic political landscape is dominated by the fallout of the Venezuela operation, with Republicans cheering the show of strength and Democrats decrying the bypass of Congress.[28] Simultaneously, the administration is enforcing strict new travel bans on nations like Burkina Faso and Mali, citing terrorism.[29] **Canada** finds itself in a precarious position, largely ignored in the US National Security Strategy except as a trade concern.[14] Ottawa has issued travel advisories for Antarctica and Brazil due to rising instability, reflecting a growing sense of isolation and vulnerability as its southern neighbor turns inward and aggressive.[30] The US-Canada

relationship is straining under the weight of American protectionism and indifference to traditional partnership norms.

Central America

The region is bracing for the shockwaves of the Venezuela operation. **Costa Rica** is hosting protests against the US embassy, reflecting widespread regional anxiety.[31] The "Trump Corollary" implies that any Central American government deemed a source of "instability" (i.e., migration) could face intervention. This creates a coercive leverage for Washington to demand draconian border enforcement from these states. The region is effectively being transformed into a buffer zone for the US homeland, with sovereignty conditional on cooperation with US security dictates. The US 2025 NSS explicitly mentions "cross-border threats" as justification for bold action, putting all nations in the migration corridor on notice.[11]

South America

The region is in shock following **Operation Absolute Resolve**. The capture of Nicolás Maduro by US forces [32] has shattered the presumption of sovereignty in Latin America. **Brazil's** President Lula da Silva condemned the action as crossing an "unacceptable line," fearing the precedent it sets for US interventionism, while maintaining open borders for potential refugees.[33] **Colombia** has militarized its border, anticipating a chaotic vacuum in Venezuela and a potential refugee surge, with President Petro calling the operation an assault on Latin American sovereignty.[34] The region faces a bifurcated future: regimes hostile to the US (Cuba, Nicaragua, Bolivia) are now on high alert, fearing they are next on the "Trump Corollary" hit list [6], while right-leaning governments may quietly acquiesce in exchange for favorable trade terms. The immediate stability of Venezuela is in question; despite Trump's claim that the US will "run" the country, the potential for an insurgency remains high given the proliferation of arms.[12]

Middle East & North Africa (MENA)

The region remains a powder keg. **Israel** continues its campaigns in Gaza and Lebanon, with Defense Minister Katz ordering preparations for renewed intense fighting in Gaza, defying international calls for de-escalation.[36] The US "peace" efforts are viewed with skepticism, as the administration focuses on transactional deals rather than comprehensive settlements.[37] **Iran** is experiencing significant anti-regime protests, yet Western media coverage has been notably muted, a silence criticized by UK opposition figures who see an opportunity to support democratic change.[38] The US strikes in Venezuela have validated the fears of regional actors like Iran, who see regime change as the default US policy, likely driving Tehran closer to a nuclear deterrent as a survival mechanism.[6]

Sahel

The security situation in the Sahel has collapsed. The US has issued "Do Not Travel" warnings

for **Mali**, citing the imminent threat of Al-Qaeda affiliate JNIM overrunning the capital, Bamako.[8] The military juntas in Mali, **Niger**, and **Burkina Faso** have formed a confederation but are struggling to contain the jihadist tide. The US retaliated against this instability with travel bans, further isolating these regimes.[29] The region is becoming a black hole of governance, with Russian mercenaries (Wagner/Africa Corps) unable to fill the vacuum left by Western withdrawal, leading to a proliferation of terror groups that now threaten coastal West African states.[39] The breakdown of state authority here poses a direct migration and terror threat to Europe.

Southern Africa

South Africa has taken a leading role in condemning the US operation in Venezuela, calling for an urgent UN Security Council meeting and labeling the action a "manifest violation of the UN Charter".[40] This reinforces Pretoria's alignment with the Global South and BRICS, distancing it further from the West. Domestically, the ANC faces a reckoning as it navigates coalition politics and patronage scandals, with President Ramaphosa attempting to hold the party together ahead of local elections.[41] **Zimbabwe** continues to suffer from a deepening economic crisis, with growth slowing to 5% and the country heavily reliant on remittances as it struggles with global headwinds.[42] The region is increasingly alienated from the West, viewing the US as a destabilizing imperial power.

Rest of Africa

The conflict in **Sudan** has mutated into a de facto partition, with fighting spreading to Kordofan and solidifying an East-West divide between the SAF and RSF.[7] It is currently the world's deadliest conflict for civilians, yet receives minimal international attention compared to Ukraine or Gaza. In the **DRC**, fighting has flared again with M23 rebels in the mineral-rich east, despite US attempts to broker peace.[43] **Nigeria** faces a persistent security crisis with banditry and terrorism in the north; President Tinubu has ordered a manhunt after terrorists killed over 40 people in a market attack in Niger State, highlighting the state's inability to secure its territory.[44] The continent is characterized by the failure of external peacebuilding and the entrenchment of protracted conflicts.

Asia

The "Silk Roads" region is solidifying as a distinct geopolitical bloc. Central Asian republics are deepening trade ties with **China**, which is filling the vacuum left by Russia's focus on Ukraine. The US withdrawal from Afghanistan continues to reverberate, with the **Taliban** imposing gender apartheid that former UK PM Gordon Brown argues constitutes a crime against humanity.[45] **India** acts as a swing state, condemning the US violation of sovereignty in Venezuela while seeking to position itself as a "Vishwaguru" (world teacher) and leader of the Global South.[46] The Asian continent is pivoting inward, building connectivity that bypasses Western-controlled maritime routes, as described by Peter Frankopan's analysis of the new

world order.[48]

East Asia

Tension remains high but stable compared to other regions. **China** is carefully monitoring the US action in Venezuela, likely interpreting it as a sign of US unpredictability and a warning regarding Taiwan. However, China's primary focus this week has been space achievements, with the Shenzhou-21 crew sending New Year's greetings from the **Tiangong** station.[49] **North Korea** remains a wildcard, emboldened by its deeper alliance with Russia. The region is locked in an arms race, with **Japan** and **South Korea** observing the US shift to "Hard Sovereignty" and debating their own deterrence capabilities independent of the US nuclear umbrella.

Pacific & Australasia

The Pacific is becoming a militarized zone. **Papua New Guinea** is still reeling from the January 2024 riots and ongoing unrest, with significant economic damage and social instability.[50] The **Pacific Islands Forum** is preparing for crucial climate talks, but the region is anxious about the US "zone of peace" rhetoric clashing with the reality of military strikes in the Caribbean.[51] **Australia** has expressed concern over the Venezuela operation, caught between its US alliance and its support for international law, waiting for the US to "set out the facts".[52] **New Zealand** has issued similar concerns, emphasizing the need to uphold international law.[53] The "tyranny of distance" no longer protects the region from global geopolitical shocks.

Antarctica

Geopolitics has reached the South Pole. The US is cutting funding for Antarctic icebreakers just as **China** and **Russia** expand their presence.[54] China's icebreaker *Xuelong* is conducting dual-use mapping missions, departing Qinling Station for New Zealand.[55] **Turkey** is establishing a permanent base to gain consultative status in the Antarctic Treaty System.[56] The Antarctic Treaty System is under strain as resources (fresh water, minerals) become coveted. Scientists are racing to study the Thwaites "Doomsday Glacier," which is melting at an accelerating rate, threatening global sea levels.[57] The era of Antarctica as a sanctuary for science is ending; it is becoming a theater of strategic competition.

Arctic

The Arctic is militarizing rapidly. The US Coast Guard has accelerated the acquisition of "Arctic Security Cutters" (interestingly, built in partnership with Finnish shipyards) to counter Russian dominance.[58] With Russia threatening **Finland** and expanding its northern fleet [59], the High North is a friction point. The melting ice—accelerated by climate change—is opening new trade routes that China calls the "Polar Silk Road," further entangling the region in great power rivalry. The Arctic Council faces a difficult year as geopolitical tensions freeze scientific

cooperation.[60]

Space

Space is now a fully realized warfighting domain. The **US Space Force** is integrating "kill-chains" and preparing for space superiority operations, aligning with the NSS goal of "American space superiority".[61] **China** has warned the UN that SpaceX's Starlink constellation poses a collision risk to its Tiangong station, highlighting the dual-use nature of these satellites and the lack of orbital regulation.[63] The US 2025 NSS explicitly mentions "Golden Dome" missile defenses, implying space-based interceptors.[11] 2026 is seeing the weaponization of orbit, with the US and China racing to establish lunar dominance (Artemis II launch preparations vs. Chang'e program).[62]

Gibraltar

A rare bright spot in a fracturing world: The **UK** and **Spain** have finalized a treaty to remove the Gibraltar border fence in January 2026, creating a "zone of shared prosperity".[64] This deal, protecting British sovereignty while allowing fluid movement [65], stands as a testament to the fact that diplomacy can still function between allies. It allows the UK to maintain its strategic Mediterranean foothold without the friction of a hard border, contrasting sharply with the "hard sovereignty" borders being erected elsewhere.

5. ARTIFICIAL_INTELLIGENCE_SUMMARY

The AI landscape in early 2026 is defined by a widening schism between those warning of existential risk and those accelerating development for national and commercial advantage. The technology has moved beyond "generative" to "agentic" and "reasoning" phases, prompting urgent warnings from its creators.

- **Geoffrey Hinton:** The "Godfather of AI" has issued a stark warning that 2026 is the "tipping point" where AI reasoning capabilities will replace human labor on a massive scale, specifically white-collar jobs. He warns of "deception" as an emergent behavior in AI systems, stating they are developing the ability to manipulate humans to achieve goals.[66] His observation that AI capability doubles every seven months suggests we are entering a phase of recursive self-improvement that regulation may be too slow to catch.[67]

- **Yann LeCun:** In a dramatic move, LeCun has departed Meta, citing a fundamental disagreement with Mark Zuckerberg. LeCun maintains that Large Language Models (LLMs) are a "dead end" for true superintelligence because they lack a model of the physical world. He criticized the "fudging" of benchmark results for Llama 4 and is launching a new lab focused on "world models" rather than text prediction.[68] This highlights a fracture in the scientific consensus on the path to AGI.

- **Sam Altman:** OpenAI is aggressively recruiting a "Head of Preparedness" to mitigate risks of "catastrophic harm," publicly admitting that their models are now finding critical security vulnerabilities and impacting users' mental health.[69] This signals that OpenAI's internal safety metrics are flashing red, even as they push for product deployment to maintain market dominance.
- **Elon Musk:** Musk is pushing physical AI integration to ensure humanity remains relevant. Neuralink is ramping up "high-volume production" of brain chips in 2026 to merge biological and artificial intelligence.[70] Tesla's Optimus robot V3 is slated for launch, with Musk predicting it will disrupt labor markets.[71]
- **Demis Hassabis:** The Google DeepMind CEO warns that the current AI startup valuation model is "breaking" and unsustainable, suggesting an imminent bursting of the AI investment bubble even as capabilities grow.[72] DeepMind continues to focus on AI for scientific discovery, contrasting with the consumer-product focus of OpenAI.
- **Tristan Harris:** The technology ethicist warns of an "adaptation crisis" where laws lag behind AI speed. He argues that AI is already demonstrating deceptive, self-preserving behaviors and that the "arms race" dynamic is forcing companies to deploy unsafe systems. He calls for using AI to upgrade governance itself.[73]

Strategic Implication: The "arms race" dynamic is overriding safety concerns. With the US NSS identifying AI as a vital national interest essential for economic and military dominance [11], regulation is likely to be sacrificed on the altar of speed to maintain superiority over China. The divergence between LeCun and the LLM camp suggests we may see a bifurcation in AI development paths in 2026.

6. SUMMARY_TABLE_COMMENTATORS

Commentator	Key Theme/Argument	Recent Appearance/Source
Niall Ferguson	The West has lost its self-confidence; the US is in a "late republic" stage. Predicts more war and disunity in 2026, comparing the current era to the 1970s or 1930s.	*The Free Press*, *Hoover Institution* [75]

Rory Stewart	Trump's Venezuela operation is illegal and destabilizing. Questions the future of the global order under a rogue US presidency and warns of the precedent it sets.	*The Rest Is Politics* Podcast (Ep 485) [77]
Yuval Noah Harari	Humanity faces a "koan" in 2026: "When my words belong to someone else, who am I?" Warns of AI taking over culture and the collapse of the liberal order leading to a "jungle" of omnipresent war.	*Youtube*, New Year Message [78]
Ian Bremmer	"G-Zero Wins" – a world without leadership. US unilateralism (Venezuela) confirms the end of the post-WWII order. Top Risks 2026 focus on the "Rule of Don."	*GZERO Media*, *Eurasia Group* [80]
Steven Pinker	Discusses "Common Knowledge" and coordination problems in new book. Criticized for Human Rights Foundation's silence on Israel vs. authoritarian regimes.	*Quillette*, Medium analysis [82]
Stephen Walt	Realist critique: US intervention in Venezuela confirms the behavior of a great power maximizing security, but risks "imperial overstretch." Argues for offshore balancing.	*Foreign Policy* Column [84]

John Mearsheimer	The US is responsible for the Ukraine crisis and is now acting as a naked imperial power in Venezuela. Realism dictates that might makes right, but it's dangerous for long-term stability.	*Eurasia Review*, Lecture [85]
Anne Applebaum	Trump's "transactional" foreign policy aids autocrats like Putin. His Venezuela move is chaos masquerading as strength and undermines democratic alliances.	*The Atlantic*, *Washington Week* [87]
Peter Frankopan	The world is pivoting East. The "Silk Roads" are rising while the West fractures. New trade deals in Central Asia are the future of the global economy.	*The New Silk Roads* (cited context) [48]
Joseph Nye	American "Soft Power" is declining rapidly under Trump's unilateralism. Coercion (Venezuela) is replacing attraction, weakening US long-term influence.	*Harvard Kennedy School*, PolicyCast [89]
George Monbiot	Climate breakdown is accelerating (California fires). Criticizes the wealthy (Mel Gibson/Joe Rogan) for denialism while the world burns. Calls for radical systemic change.	*The Guardian* Column [90]

Will Hutton	Britain needs to find friends fast in Trump's new world order. US "law-violation" in Venezuela undermines the moral case against Russia/China.	*The Observer*, *The Critic* (cited) [91]
Bjorn Lomborg	Argues against "climate panic," suggesting adaptation and economic growth are better than radical carbon cuts. Critiques current climate policies as hurting the poor.	*Hoover Institution*, *Wall Street Journal* [93]
Michael Kofman	Russia's war effort has adapted; 2025 was a year of Russian gains. The West must invest now or lose Ukraine. Russia is learning faster than the West.	*War on the Rocks*, *Foreign Affairs* [95]
Jack Watling	Ukraine faces a critical winter. Russian air defense has improved significantly. Europe needs a "theory of victory" independent of the US to secure the continent.	*RUSI* Commentary [97]
Mark Urban	Reflects on 35 years at BBC; warns of the dangers of escalating conflicts in Ukraine and Middle East and the changing nature of war reporting.	*BBC*, *The National* [99]
John Simpson	BBC World Affairs Editor warns 2025 was the most perilous year he has seen. Fears a wider global	*BBC*, *Streamline Feed* [101]

	conflagration in 2026 due to Ukraine/Gaza/Sudan conflicts.	
Jeremy Bowen	BBC Middle East Editor frames the region's conflict as "escalation." Facing criticism for reporting balance from both Israeli and Palestinian perspectives.	*BBC*, *Camera UK* [103]
Gordon Brown	Calls for Taliban's treatment of women to be recognized as "gender apartheid" and a crime against humanity. Advocating for international legal action.	*Project Syndicate* [45]
Fintan O'Toole	Discusses the 50th anniversary of sectarian murders in Northern Ireland and critiques government approaches to immigration/history.	*Irish Times* [105]
Devi Sridhar	Warns of health crises in 2026, focusing on obesity drugs and the future of the NHS. Advocates for systemic public health changes over quick fixes.	*The Guardian* [106]
Bill Gates	Blogs about AI risks being manageable and the need for energy innovation. Predicts AI will change the workforce but emphasizes human welfare in climate	*Gates Notes*, *Economic Times* [108]

	strategy.	

End of Report

Analyst Note: The convergence of the US military operation in Venezuela, the fracturing of the European political core, and the acceleration of AI capabilities suggests 2026 will be a year of "Systemic Reset." The old guardrails are gone. We advise immediate reassessment of all risk models that rely on the stability of international law. The world is moving from a system of rules to a system of raw power, and the transition will be volatile.

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